



Fabergé Easter eggs

△ **Coronation Egg**, which contained a replica of Tsarina Alexandra's coronation coach

In the Russian Orthodox Church, Easter has always been the most important date in the calendar. After fasting for weeks during Lent, the faithful could look forward to the climax of the celebrations on Easter Sunday, when eggs – one of the prohibited foods – would be exchanged. These ranged from real, hand-painted eggs to artificial ones, produced as presents for ladies. The most sumptuous of all were the jewelled eggs created by Carl Fabergé for the tsarinas (empresses) of Russia.

Fabergé designed his first imperial egg in 1885, when Alexander III commissioned one as a gift for his wife. From the outset, Carl was determined to do more than simply create an aesthetic arrangement of valuable gems. Instead, he hoped to delight his royal client by placing a surprise within a surprise. Inside his plain, enamelled Hen Egg, there was a golden yolk, containing a tiny golden hen. This in



Lily of the Valley Egg, a gift from Nicholas to Alexandra featuring Art Nouveau styling

turn could be opened up to reveal two further surprises: a miniature, diamond crown and a ruby pendant.

The Hen Egg proved a huge success and Fabergé was engaged to create a similar gift each year. This became something of a royal tradition, lasting for over 30 years, until the outbreak of the Revolution. The most exquisite example, perhaps, is the Coronation Egg, which was ordered as a gift for

the newly crowned empress, Alexandra. The “surprise” was a perfect, miniature replica of the coach that was used in the ceremony, while the colour scheme of the egg-shell echoed the design of her dress. A decade later, in April 1907, the Tsarina received the Rose Trellis Egg to commemorate the birth of her first and only son, Alexei. Decorated with pink enamel roses and a lattice of rose-cut diamonds, the egg contained a diamond necklace and a portrait of the young Tsarevich Alexei.

Monsieur Fabergé's work reaches the limits of perfection



Carl Fabergé's workshop in St Petersburg, Russia, pictured around 1910, after Carl and his brother Agathon expanded their business to increase capacity

Review

Paris Exposition Universelle, 1900

Key dates

1793–2013

